

A starting checklist for genuine engagement

Twelve questions worth asking before you commission a single session. If you can answer these honestly, the engagement has a chance of changing a decision. If you can't, that's the work to do first.

Most engagement fails before it starts. Not because the facilitation is poor, but because the decision it was meant to inform had already been made, or the people most affected were never really in the room. This checklist is the set of questions I work through with a client before any method is chosen. Be honest with the answers. A blank is more useful than a hopeful one.

Before you start

1. **What decision will this engagement change?** Name it. If the answer is "none yet" or "it's for the report", stop and fix that first.
2. **Can that decision still move?** If the brief, the budget and the timeline are already fixed, you are running consultation theatre, and people will know.
3. **What would you do differently depending on what you hear?** If you can't describe two different actions, the input has nowhere to land.

Who is in the room

4. **Who is most affected by this decision?** Not who is easiest to reach. Who carries the consequences.
5. **Who is hardest to reach, and what would it take to include them?** The convenient room and the right room are rarely the same.
6. **Is anyone in the room only there to be seen to be there?** Tokenism shows in the result even when the process looks sound.
7. **Have you matched support to need?** Reimbursement, plain materials, timing, access. If taking part costs people, you have skewed who can.

How you will run it

8. **Have you chosen the method to fit the question, or the question to fit a method you like?**
The method follows the question, not the other way around.
9. **Are you clear about what input can and cannot change?** Say it out loud at the start, then honour the line.
10. **Who holds the pen?** Reacting to a finished draft is consultation. Shaping the answer is co-design. Know which one you are actually offering.

What happens after

11. **How will people hear what changed because of them?** Closing the loop is not a courtesy. It is what makes the next round possible.
12. **How will you know it worked?** Name the patient-centred outcome, specific and measurable, before you begin. If you can't name what changed, it didn't.

The test I hold the work to: if the organisation does nothing differently because of what it heard, the engagement did not happen. It was performed.

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